

THE MARKETS ON THURSDAY				change †
Sensex	80,015.9	▲	899.7	
Nifty	24,765.9	▲	285.4	
Nifty Futures‡	24,854.3	▲	88.4	
Dollar	₹91.6		₹92.2 ‡	
Euro	₹106.5		₹107.0 ‡	
Brent Crude (\$/bbl)	83.6 *			
Gold (10gm)**	₹1,59,943	▼	₹1,954	

† Over previous close; ‡ (January) Premium on Nifty Spot; ‡ Previous close; * At 9pm IST; ** Market rate exclusive of VAT; Source: BSE

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IN BRIEF

Centre reviewing Rodtep scheme to justify continuation

The Centre is reviewing the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Export Products (Rodtep) scheme to assess and justify its continuation, according to a senior government official. The review, suggested by the Ministry of Finance, is part of an exercise to rationalise central-sector schemes to enhance efficiency and merge existing schemes to reduce overlaps. The expenditure finance committee will make the final call, the person cited above said. “The scheme (along with others) is going through a third-party assessment,” the official said, adding that the desirability of the scheme would be considered and whether it needed modifying.

‘SWIFT’ norms soon for cross-border payments

SWIFT, a global messaging network facilitating cross-border payments, on Thursday said banks across the world, including major Indian banks like State Bank of India (SBI), HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, and Axis Bank, will begin rolling out a new framework aimed at making cross-border retail payments faster, more predictable and cheaper for consumers and small businesses. India will be amongst the first countries, which will benefit as one of the top remittance-receiving nations globally.

Urban-rural FMCG gap narrowed in Q3: NIQ

The gap between Indian urban and rural fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) market narrowed in the October-December quarter, market researcher NIQ said in its latest report. While “rural markets continued to outpace urban consumption for the eighth consecutive quarter, the growth gap narrowed in the third quarter of FY26,” the researcher stated. The overall market growth moderated to 7.8 per cent on account of a higher festival season base and transition due to the change in goods and services tax (GST) rate cuts.

■ Auto retail sales record best February ever

China sets economy’s growth target below 5%

Every March, China’s leaders gather in Beijing’s Great Hall of the People to announce how much the world’s second-largest economy is expected to grow that year. It doesn’t change much from year to year. On Thursday, the target for 2026 was set at between 4.5 per cent and 5 per cent. It was the first time in more than three decades that the benchmark was placed below the 5 per cent mark, an acknowledgment that China is on a slower growth path.

■ China calls for AI throughout its economy, tech breakthroughs

NPCI signals identity reboot

Looks to build brand recall beyond the platforms it powers

AJINKYA KAWALE
Mumbai, 5 March

The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), the organisation that runs India’s key digital payment rails, is planning a major branding exercise as it seeks to reposition itself as a technology-led infrastructure provider and strengthen its profile in India and overseas.

According to people familiar with the development, the apex payments body is reviewing its brand architecture across the NPCI Group, including its subsidiaries, to bring greater harmonisation to its identity. The push comes at a time when India’s digital payments boom has created an unusual paradox: hundreds of millions of users

Hiding in plain sight

- NPCI reviewing brand architecture across group entities
- Reset aims to sharpen domestic and global positioning
- Seeks stronger recall as UPI and other products scale
- Move to tighten brand governance across subsidiaries
- Plans to foreground deeptech capabilities

rely on platforms such as the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), the RuPay card network, and toll payments through Fastag, yet relatively few recognise the institution that powers these systems. The apex payments body wants to change that.



ILLUSTRATION: AJAYA MOHANTY

NPCI did not respond to *Business Standard’s* request for comment.

The branding revamp will also seek to address deeper challenges around NPCI’s identity, including attracting technology talent and positioning the organisation

as a deeptech player working across payments, digital infrastructure, artificial intelligence (AI), machine learning (ML), and blockchain.

“Many believe that NPCI stands for the Nuclear Power Corporation of India, when all it does is build digital payments products,” a source said, adding that it was important for people to recognise the organisation behind India’s digital payments ecosystem, which is increasingly exporting its stack globally.

The total cost of the group-level branding exercise has yet to be estimated but is expected to be sizeable given the scale of products and subsidiaries operated by NPCI.

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WORLD 10 ▶

Voting concludes in Nepal’s first election since Gen Z protests



TAKE TWO 15 ▶

An AI summit afterglow for Indian hospitality sector

BACK 16 ▶

Women startup founders get just ₹4 for every ₹100 raised



Indian gas firms may cut industrial supply if Qatar halt persists

SHUBHANGI MATHUR
New Delhi, 5 March

India’s gas firms may consider re-viewing allocations to industrial users if the production halt by QatarEnergy is prolonged amid the deepening crisis in West Asia, said three senior government officials familiar with the development.

However, gas allocation for priority sectors, such as domestic piped natural gas (PNG) and compressed natural gas (CNG), would not be curtailed, they added.

“India consumes 195 million standard cubic metres per day (mmscmd) of natural gas. Of this, 60 mmscmd is not available due to the QatarEnergy production halt. If this continues, we may re-prioritise sectors within the country; industrial usage may be impacted,” said a top government official.

QatarEnergy has halted production of liquefied natural gas (LNG) amid attacks on its facilities as tensions rise in West Asia. Qatar is India’s largest LNG supplier. Industrial players have been informed in advance and asked to look for alternate fuels such as liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), fuel oil, among other options, in case of a cut, said a senior executive from a gas company.

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Ripple effects

- India in talks with US to secure marine cover for vessels shipping oil from West Asia
- Gas allocation for domestic piped natural gas won’t be curtailed
- GAIL weighs supply cuts to gas customers after Petronet LNG force majeure
- Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals shuts some units at its refinery
- Adani Total Gas nearly triples gas prices for large industrial consumers

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No issue can be resolved through military conflict: PM



Thursday, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi stating that the two countries agree that no issue, whether in Ukraine or in West Asia, can be resolved through military conflict.

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Additional war-risk insurance lifts Gulf-India airfares 3-4 times

Additional war-risk insurance premiums of ₹30-40 lakh for a narrow-body flight and ₹90 lakh-₹1 crore for a wide-body flight are a key reason why spot airfares between India and West Asia have shot up to three-four times.

- Rice exporters seek urgent aid as shipping chaos bites

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- US, Israel intensify attacks on Tehran

Mkts snap 3-day losing streak, rebound over 1%

KHUSHBOO TIWARI
Mumbai, 5 March

Benchmark indices rebounded on Thursday, rising more than 1 per cent after three sessions of sharp losses, as global risk appetite improved despite continued tensions in West Asia.

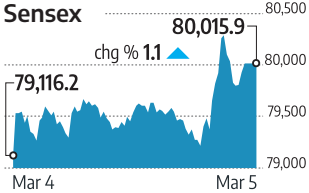
After closing at its lowest level in nearly 11 months in the previous session, the Sensex rose 900 points, or 1.14 per cent, to end at 80,016, while the Nifty 50 gained 285 points, or 1.2 per cent, to close at 24,766.

In the preceding three sessions, both indices had declined about 4 per cent as the escalating conflict between Iran and the United States pushed oil prices higher and triggered concerns about inflation and economic growth.

Most Asian and European markets also advanced, tracking a positive close on Wall Street overnight. However, geopolitical tensions remained elevated. Iran vowed to intensify retaliation against US strikes and avenge the sinking of one of its warships as the conflict entered its sixth day.

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Fighting back



Nifty 50

24,480.5	24,765.9	▲ 1.2 % CHG
Mar 4	Mar 5	

Top 5 gainers

As on Mar 5	Price (₹)	1-day chg (%)
Adani Ports & SEZ	1,499.0	4.5
Larsen & Toubro	4,033.0	3.9
NTPC	378.2	3.4
Reliance Industries	1,389.8	3.3
Bharat Electronics	460.0	3.0

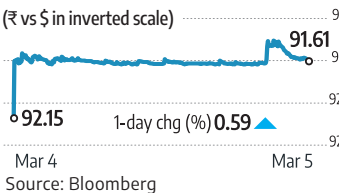
Source: Bloomberg, exchange



SECTION II, P1
Markets react strongly to geopolitics but eventually move on: Jim Rogers

- Gold rises on safe-haven rush, dollar limits gains

Rupee relief



₹ posts best day in a month on RBI \$ sales

ANJALI KUMARI
Mumbai, 5 March

A day after hitting a fresh low and breaching the 92 mark against the dollar, the rupee on Thursday gained 0.6 per cent to become the best-performing Asian currency, supported by dollar sales by the central bank.

Dealers estimated that the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) sold around \$5-6 billion during the day.

The domestic currency had fallen to a fresh low of 92.30 per dollar during Wednesday’s session, weighed down by escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia.

On Thursday, the rupee settled at 91.61 per dollar, compared with the previous close of 92.15 per dollar. It was also one of only two Asian currencies that appreciated against the greenback during the session.

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